

What else to watch: *Godzilla* (1954, p.129) ■ *Moby Dick* (1956) ■ *The Deep* (1977) ■ *Piranha* (1978) ■ *Alien* (1979, p.243) ■ *Open Water* (2003) ■ *The Shark Is Still Working* (2007) ■ *All Is Lost* (2013)

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What this movie is about, and where it succeeds best, is the primordial level of fear.

Gene Siskel
Chicago Tribune, 1975

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It's a theme-park moment—the shark is clearly mechanical, a prop on a hydraulic crane, but we don't mind because *Jaws* is as much a ride as it is a movie.

When Steven Spielberg's monster movie was released in June 1975, there was a sense that something new had arrived. Adapted from a best-selling novel by Peter Benchley about a shark that terrorizes a small beach community, *Jaws* sold 25 million tickets in 38 days—it started big and swelled to mammoth proportions. Studio executives quickly realized that they were onto something—*Jaws 2* was rushed into production and came out in 1978. Spielberg had invented the “summer event movie”—the action-packed blockbuster aimed at summer audiences that became Hollywood's great obsession for the next four decades.

Pure entertainment

Jaws changed American cinema, which, for the first half of the 1970s, had been in thrall to low-key, European-style movies



with deliberately tricky characters and ambiguous moral codes. Spielberg's big-fish tale was a throwback to the fun-house origins of the moving image—it was pure entertainment, a roller coaster that promised scares but at the same time sought to reassure its audience. The movie contained all the elements that would go on to make a typical Spielberg sideshow: ambitious special effects, a high-concept story, cute kids, a small-town American hero who finds himself out of his depth, and plenty of opportunities for marketing.

Brody (Roy Scheider, center) wants to close the resort, but is overruled by the mayor (Murray Hamilton, left), who fears that rumors of a shark attack will ruin the tourist season.

After *Jaws* came the *Star Wars* movies, Spielberg's *Indiana Jones* saga, *Back to the Future*, and then the superhero mega-franchises of the 21st century. But, looking back, the picture that spawned these behemoths is a very different creature. *Jaws*, in comparison, is a relatively modest adventure, its chief spectacle a rubber shark so unconvincing that Spielberg »

“This was not a boat accident.”

Hooper / Jaws